

Thomomys bottae

Botta's pocket gopher



Length 3¼–8 in (8–20 cm)
Tail 2¼–3¾ in (5.5–9.5 cm)
Weight 2½–9 oz (80–250 g)
Location W. USA to N. Mexico
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern



Botta's pocket gopher lives mainly alone. It digs an extensive burrow system (lodge) in loose soil, using its strong forelegs equipped with large claws. This gopher stays underground most of its life, consuming roots, tubers, bulbs, and other subsurface plant parts. It is grayish brown above and brownish orange below, and has adaptations typical of burrowers, such as a flat head, long whiskers, small eyes, and small ears closed by flaps.



Dipodomys merriami

Merriam's kangaroo rat



Length 3–4 in (7.5–10 cm)
Tail 4¾–7 in (12–18.2 cm)
Weight 1½–2 oz (32–53 g)
Location S.W. USA to N. Mexico
Social unit Group
Status Least concern



Relatively large back legs and feet, for kangaroo-like hopping, and a very long, slender, tufted tail, for balance, allow Merriam's kangaroo rat to move at high speed over sandy soil in its desert habitat. The silky fur is gray above and white on the underparts, with narrow dark gray and white stripes along the flanks. This kangaroo rat regularly has energetic dust-baths to keep its fur and skin clean. It digs, burrows, or searches for food, especially cockle- and sand-burr seeds in winter, and cactus seeds in summer.

Heteromys catopterus

Overlook spiny pocket mouse



Length 5–5¼ in (13–13.5 cm)
Tail 6½ in (16.5 cm)
Weight 2¼–3 oz (78–86 g)
Location N. South America
Social unit Group
Status Not evaluated



Discovered in 2010 in the high, wet mountain forests of coastal Venezuela, the overlook spiny pocket mouse occurs from 1,148 to 8,063 ft (350–2,450 m). It belongs to a group of spiny mice so-called because of their coarse, spiny fur. This species has darker fur than more widespread relatives of the lowlands, and is adapted to cool, high altitudes. Scientists speculate that it may have had a more extensive distribution during the last Ice Age. Although it lives in a remote location, it is possible that its survival will be threatened by global warming. Its habits are probably similar to other *Heteromys* spiny mice, emerging from burrows at night to take seeds and other plant material—gathered in cheek pouches for storage in underground caches.

Microdipodops megacephalus

Dark kangaroo mouse



Length 2½–3 in (6.5–7.5 cm)
Tail 2½–4¼ in (6.5–10.5 cm)
Weight ¾–¾ oz (10–17 g)
Location S.W. USA
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern



The dark kangaroo mouse is named after its dark-furred, large back legs, which it uses for hopping and leaping over sand dunes and soft, dry soil.

Castor canadensis

American beaver



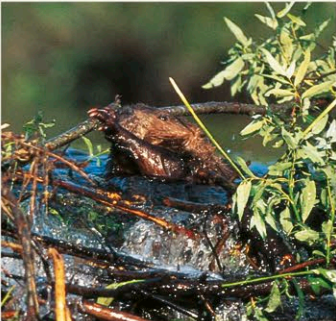
Length 32–35 in (80–90 cm)
Tail 8–12 in (20–30 cm)
Weight 33–44 lb (15–20 kg)
Location North America
Social unit Group
Status Least concern



The American beaver is well adapted to aquatic life. Its feet are webbed for swimming and the flat, scaly tail slaps the surface as a loud alarm signal. Underwater, the ears and nose shut with valvelike flaps and the lips close behind the incisor teeth, which can then be used for nibbling and gnawing. The eyes have a third, transparent eyelid (known as the nictitating membrane) to see below the surface. Long whiskers feel the way in the dark. The American beaver feeds on the leaves, twigs, and bark of bankside trees and water plants. It also gnaws and fells small trees to eat the tender shoots and leaves. It uses the fallen branches and small trunks for building its lodge (see panel) and for dam construction, dragging them to the dam site in their strong jaws. Following a gestation period of 107 days, the 1–6 kits (young beavers) are born fully furred and are weaned within 2 months. On an average, 2–4 kits are born.

The upperparts are gray-brown, the underparts pure white. The prominent eyes, large ears, long snout, and bushy whiskers indicate adaptation for a nocturnal lifestyle. Like many small desert rodents, this species is a seasonal opportunist. In summer, it consumes mainly insects; in winter, it switches to being a seed-hoarder in its burrow nest, carrying food items in its external cheek pouches. It also stores food as body fat in its dumpy tail. Each male dark kangaroo mouse aggressively defends a territory of up to 7,900 square yd (6,600 square m) against others of its species. Female territories tend to be much smaller, only about 480 square yd (400 square m). Each female produces a litter of 2–7 offspring.

LAKESIDE LODGE



Beavers rest by day in their lodge—a pile of mud and sticks built in a pool or lake. The lodge's underwater entrances keep out land-based predators. The beaver digs channels and builds dams of mud, stones, and branches to maintain a system of waterways. These activities are believed by some to harm crops and trees, and affect local wildlife. An alternate view is that beavers reduce local floods, and help return the habitat to its natural state.

TWO COATS

The American beaver's long guard coat (outer fur) varies from yellowish brown to black, although it is usually reddish brown. The dense underfur is dark gray and retains body heat even in freezing water.

Castor fiber

Eurasian beaver



Length 32–35 in (80–90 cm)
Tail 8–12 in (20–30 cm)
Weight 33–44 lb (15–20 kg)
Location Europe to C. Asia
Social unit Group
Status Least concern



Similar to the American beaver (see right) in appearance, habits, and lifestyle, the Eurasian beaver is usually heavier. As in its close cousin, glands at the base of the tail produce an oily, waterproofing secretion that is spread through the fur when grooming. In areas with many natural waterways, the Eurasian beaver does not build a sticks-and-mud lodge but digs tunnels in the bank, with underwater entrances. It eats bark, leaves, and plants, and can stay submerged for 20 minutes.

